

Lesson 14

Case Study: Problem Solving in Teams



Warm-Up

1. What are some common workplace challenges you've faced or observed?
2. How did you or the team address the issue?
3. What solutions or strategies have been implemented to solve the problem?





Case Study

The marketing team at XYZ Corporation faced significant workplace challenges during a major product launch.

Communication breakdowns between team members and departments led to delays and misunderstandings. Additionally, conflicting opinions on the campaign's creative direction caused tension and hindered progress.

To overcome these challenges, the team leader implemented regular team meetings and encouraged open communication. Team members were also empowered to share their ideas and concerns, fostering a collaborative and inclusive environment.

Through these efforts, the team was able to improve communication, resolve conflicts, and deliver a successful campaign. The product launch exceeded sales expectations, and the team received positive feedback from stakeholders.

Case Study Analysis

Answer the following questions:

1. What strategies did the team use to overcome communication breakdowns?
2. How did empowering team members contribute to the team's success?
3. What lessons can be learned from this case study about effective team collaboration and communication?
4. How can teams apply these strategies to their own work environment?



Practice

ACTIVITY 1: REFLECTION ON PAST EXPERIENCES

Instructions:

1. Reflect on a time you faced a problem in a team setting. You should consider:
 - What the problem was
 - How you felt about it
 - What actions you took to address it
 - What the outcome was
2. In **pairs**, share your experiences, focusing on the process of problem-solving you went through.
3. As a class, facilitate a discussion on common themes or strategies that emerged from your experiences.

Discussions:

1. How did collaboration contribute to the team's problem-solving process?
2. What role did brainstorming play in generating potential solutions?

ACTIVITY 2: QUIZ

Choose the best answer.

1. **What approach best resolves team conflict?**
 - a) Encourage open discussion
 - b) Allow dominant voices to lead
 - c) Mandate a solution
 - d) Ignore the conflict

2. How should you respond to frequent interruptions in meetings?

- a) Gently remind of speaking etiquette
- b) Ignore the interruptions
- c) Continue talking anyway
- d) Exclude them from discussions

3. Which factor is key when choosing a solution?

- a) Implementation speed
- b) Group popularity
- c) Long-term feasibility
- d) Lowest cost

4. What does diversity bring to problem-solving?

- a) Increased confusion
- b) Varied perspectives
- c) Longer discussions
- d) More conflicts

5. How can a leader ensure all opinions are heard?

- a) Limit discussion time
- b) Encourage quieter members actively
- c) Let vocal members dominate
- d) Use a strict Q&A format



Production

ACTIVITY 1: SCENARIO-BASED SOLUTIONS

To assess problem solving skills, teamwork, and communication in a team setting, read each scenario and answer the questions that follow.

1. Your team is working on a project with a tight deadline. However, one team member is consistently late for meetings and misses important deadlines.
 - How would you address this issue with the team member?
 - What strategies would you use to ensure the team stays on track and meets the deadline?
2. A critical bug is discovered in your team's software product just before launch. The team is under pressure to fix the issue quickly.
 - How would you approach problem solving in this situation?
 - What steps would you take to ensure the bug is fixed and the product launches on time?
3. A team member has different opinions on the project's direction, causing tension among team members.
 - How would you facilitate a discussion to resolve the issue?
 - What strategies would you use to ensure all team members are heard and valued?

ACTIVITY 2: ROLE REVERSAL SIMULATION

Instructions:

- Work in pairs and assign each other the roles for the scenario.
- In your roles, act out the scenario provided for 5 minutes, addressing the problem presented.
- After the first role play, switch roles and act out another scenario for another 5 minutes.
- After completing both rounds, share insights on what you learned from experiencing the different perspectives.

Scenario 1: Team Member Not Meeting Deadlines

- **Project Manager:** You need to address the issue of a team member who consistently misses deadlines, affecting the team's progress.
- **Team Member:** You explain your reasons for the delays and express any personal challenges that may have impacted your work.

Scenario 2: Task Delegation Conflict

- **Project Manager:** You need to delegate responsibilities for an upcoming project. Explain to the team member the importance of their contributions and negotiate how they can manage their workload effectively.
- **Team Member:** You feel overwhelmed by your current tasks and express your concerns about taking on additional responsibilities. Aim to find a solution that allows you to maintain your workload while ensuring the project progresses smoothly.

Debrief

1. Did your approach change when you switched roles? How?
2. What strategies helped you communicate effectively?
3. Was it challenging to argue for the other person's position? Why?
4. How can understanding different roles improve teamwork?
5. What did you learn about collaboration through this exercise?



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
Problem-solving	Used in identifying, analyzing, and resolving problems or challenges.	<i>The team demonstrated excellent problem-solving skills by resolving complex issues efficiently.</i>
Collaboration	Team members work together, sharing ideas and expertise.	<i>Collaboration among team members was key to finding solution.</i>
Brainstorming	Used in generating a wide range of potential solutions.	<i>Brainstorming helped us think outside the box.</i>
Implementations	Used in putting the chosen solution into action.	<i>The implementation phase requires careful planning and execution.</i>
What are our options?	This question encourages teams to generate and explore potential solutions.	<i>What are our options for resolving this issue?</i>
How can we resolve this?	Used in encouraging collaborative problem-solving, fostering a solution-focused approach.	<i>How can we resolve this challenge effectively?</i>



Homework

BRAINSTORMING

Instructions:

1. Work in pairs/groups. Read the scenario below, discuss and solve the problem together
2. **Scenario:** Your team is planning a company event, but the venue has just been cancelled due to unforeseen circumstances. You have 50 guests attending in two hours.
3. **Tasks:** Identify potential solutions (brainstorming). Evaluate and choose the best solution. Plan implementation.
4. Time limit is 3-5 minutes audio recording.
5. Submit the recorded presentation.